

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 579

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Marzie Thomas of Memphis.

WHEREAS, we were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Marzie Thomas of Memphis, the former publisher of *The Tri-State Defender* and public servant, a community leader who was greatly admired and respected by all; and

WHEREAS, Marzie Thomas spent more than sixteen years at *The Tri-State Defender*, where she rose from advertising manager to general manager, editor, and eventually publisher, becoming one of the few Black women in that role at the time; and

WHEREAS, her leadership helped sustain the historic Black newspaper through turbulent years of transition, financial hardship, and evolving media landscapes; she had a rapport with the community, the advertisers, and the churches; and

WHEREAS, after leaving *The Tri-State Defender*, she worked briefly with Art Gilliam's WLOK Radio before she joined the office of U.S. Representative Steve Cohen (D-Tenn.) as a special assistant for veterans' affairs and community outreach in 2007; and

WHEREAS, an extremely talented administrator and outstanding public servant, Marzie Thomas understood the district and worked tirelessly to meet the needs of Congressman Cohen's constituents; and

WHEREAS, her outstanding efforts and dedication to the people of Memphis and Shelby County led to her being named Congressman Cohen's deputy district director in 2009 and promoted to district director in 2013, rightfully serving as his top aide in the Congressional district; and

WHEREAS, a graduate of Booker T. Washington High School and LeMoyne-Owen College, Marzie Thomas was a lifelong member of East Trigg Avenue Baptist Church where she

sang as a soloist in the choir and grew up under the spiritual mentorship of the legendary Reverend Dr. Herbert Brewster, a noted gospel composer; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Thomas was deeply devoted to her family, and she always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, a beloved family matriarch, Marzie Thomas is survived by her two daughters, Marthel Ellison and Richara Thomas; her sister, Aimee Gates; and her granddaughter, Madison Ellison; and

WHEREAS, she was preceded in death by her husband, Alonzo Thomas, Jr., and her brother, the Reverend Richard Gates; and

WHEREAS, Marzie Thomas leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all her chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Marzie Thomas of Memphis, reflecting fondly upon her impeccable character and her stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and extend our condolences to the family of Mrs. Thomas.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.

